



SIPRA DAS

semantics and the photo opportunity to contrast with the Congress's desperate quest for numbers. But the NDA camp isn't without worries. Although there are no obvious cracks in the alliance, BJP is concerned about two hope balloons floated by the Congress spin masters. The Shiv Sena indicated in its mouthpiece, *Samna*, that the "deal is good for the nation and that the Leftists are anti-national". This the Congress interpreted as support till Executive President Uddhav Thackeray said firmly "we will vote with BJP." But that hasn't stopped the Congress from using its corporate and political network to convince the Shiv Sena to "at least abstain". A similar trial balloon was floated citing Akali support for the Sikh prime minister. Apparently, senior SAD leader S.S. Dhindsa believes there is some support for the deal in Punjab. SAD chief Parkash Singh Badal though shot down hopes with a blunt "the sun may rise in the west but we will not support the Congress."

At the 123-year-old Congress, they

help the party's secular credentials and dent the anti-Muslim perception of the N-Deal. While that may be debatable, the fact is the installation of a Congressman also means one vote less taking the target rate higher.

As the Congress negotiates its way to majority, the Opposition will miss no chance to ambush. There is a growing demand that if the draft of the safeguards agreement with IAEA could be released to over 45 countries, it

WITHIN THE CONGRESS
there is unease over speculation about berths for SP and the Amar Singh missives to the PM on UPA ministers.



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Congress can march on its own at all.

Much of this churn must have triggered a sense of déjà vu for NDA which met under the leadership of prime minister designate Advani on July 9 with all its constituents. Mindful of the fact that this is an era of coalitions, the BJP leadership is also keeping a sharp eye on the breakup of UNPA. Feelers have already been sent to AGP, INLD, and AIADMK who are all opposed to the Congress-led UPA. All the NDA allies held a show of strength at Advani's house on July 9 to provide the right

BATTLE CRY: NDA (top) and the Left ramp up their opposition

know a week is a long time in politics and they have over 10 days to get set. The first trial of strength will be to get a speaker in place of Somnath Chatterjee. Several names are being bandied about ranging from Home Minister Shivraj Patil, who some believe will solve two problems at once, to Kishore Chandra Deo of Andhra Pradesh. There is also the belief that installing a Muslim as the speaker may

could be released to the public as well. Karat has already made a demand for it to be made public and BJP wants the document to be made public before the trust vote. Perceptions and misconceptions will then ramp up the hurdle rate of acquiring support from those perched on the "undecided" bench. There will be other hurdles for sure, but the outcome will only be known when the voting buttons are finally pressed.

India and the world will witness yet another round of pyrotechnics that the world's largest democracy has come to be known for. Indeed, Parliament debate on the confidence motion would see the launch of many a poll campaign. Karat has already launched the Left campaign on July 9 when he called the Congress-led UPA "anti-people". Advani too is sure to launch the NDA campaign from the Sansad Bhavan and smaller parties will follow suit. As the parties cadge and cobble support, for the next few weeks, India will be suspended between hope and fear—hope of an end to uncertainty and fear of descending into chaos.

with Shyam Lal Yadav, Farzand Ahmed and Amarnath K. Menon